The Three Stages of the Great Empowerment

Mahābhiṣekatrikrama · Toh 1275 · Derge Tengyur
དབང་ཆེན་པ་རིམ་པ་གསུམ་པ

The Three Stages of the Great Empowerment, known in Sanskrit as the Mahābhiṣekatrikrama and in Tibetan as Wang Chenpo Rimpa Sumpa, is a short anonymous verse instruction on the completion stage of tantric practice in the Hevajra tradition. Opening with homage to Hevajra, it describes in terse and allusive verses the yoga of union with a consort, the control and reversal of the inner winds, the progression through the joys and the secret grounds, and the resulting nondual wisdom body, free of apprehended and apprehender, in which phenomena appear like reflections in a mirror. It is Toh 1275 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the Indian commentaries and instructional works on the tantras.

In the language of India: ma hā a bhi ṣe ka tri kra ma nā ma. In the language of Tibet: The Three Stages of the Great Empowerment.

Homage to glorious Hevajra.

One who wishes to accomplish the wisdom of the consort (prajñā)
must know the bounds of the dharma of desire and of the two organs.
Having known that, what is to be made the object
is the glance that draws her in, and the tip where the limit is exhausted.
The two joys of the lotus gather in the center:
this should be known as the ten secret grounds.
The stamens of the method, the three, and the jewel:
what is desired in the consort is the single buddha.
When the downward-moving wind meets, is reversed and enters the center,
it fills every ground and every place, wherever one wishes.
Free of conceptual thought, the aspiration is twofold in form;
having come to know all the parts of the moments
of the fourfold sesame seed of lovemaking (rati),
by knowing the four tastes one brings about the four tastes.
At the time of the ground of wind,
by stirring with hūṃ phaṭ, the karmic wind and fire arise;
the count of the winds of the four elements is like a wheel;
at the time of earth, one follows the reversal.
The water is filtered and held by the wind, with the letter;

standing upright, the upward-moving wind is stopped.
Through a special concentration
the two unite, and in the bhaga the four winds are pressed down;
unmoving, this is called subduing the four māras.
By holding a slight union,
it is taught that the first ground, nonconceptuality, is attained.
At the end of seven and a half, at the end of seven and a half,
the two meet like rock and beam.
As taught, the wisdom is inconceivable,
and all of it is clear, like a conch:
this is the perfectly complete buddha,
whose great qualities cannot be fully told.
If the suns of the consort,
the drop, its color transformed, are joined as before,
being able to mingle like butter or water,
though they abide distinct there is no confusion.
It is not conventional appearance;
the two things are always mingled.
No one at all is able to see it;
its qualities cannot be exhausted by the tongue.
Even for an eon it neither perishes nor parts:
the wisdom body free of apprehended and apprehender,
in which, in time, phenomena are like a mirror.

The Three Stages of the Great Empowerment, an instruction on the completion stage, is complete.

Translator's Notes

• This is a terse, allusive verse instruction on the sexual yoga of the completion stage, and several lines are obscure; they have been rendered as literally as sense allows. The line "the glance that draws her in, and the tip where the limit is exhausted" contains the unclear syllable shir and is uncertain. "Even for an eon it neither perishes nor parts" reads 'jigs ("fear") as 'jig ("perish"), which the sense seems to require. In "free of apprehended and apprehender" the text's bra la ba is taken as a slip for bral ba, "free of". "Seven and a half" translates brgyad phyed literally; its technical reference is unclear.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.